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IF YOU COULD TALK TO YOUR YOUNGER SELF,
WHAT WOULD YOU SAY?

CARLOS HILADO MEMORIAL STATE UNIVERSITY

THE OFFICIAL LITERARY FOLIO OF
THE TECHNOPACER-FORTUNE TOWNE

A MESSAGE TO YOUR YOUNGER SELF

"When Apples are Mountains"
(A Message to your Younger Self) VOL. 11

June 2026
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WHEN APPPLES ARE MOUNTAINS

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MESSAGE

There is a particular cruelty in growing older that no one prepares you for: you finally understand the things you needed to hear, but the person who needed to hear them is gone. We write to our younger selves because we cannot reach them any other way, only through paper, only through memory pretending to be a letter. What we offer is not correction. We are not trying to fix who they were or scold them for not knowing better. We are trying to sit beside them, quietly, the way you would sit beside someone in a waiting room, not to change the outcome but to make the waiting less lonely.

And maybe that is enough. Maybe the younger self does not need saving, only witnessing. Someone, even a future self, even an imagined one, who finally says: I see what that cost you. I see how hard you tried, even when no one noticed. Growth, after all, is not the erasure of who we were. It is the slow, deliberate act of looking back without flinching, and choosing to forgive the parts of us that didn't know better yet.

—Associate Editor, Sarah Gwyneth Sancho

VOL. 11
JUNE 2026

THE OFFICIAL LITERARY FOLIO OF
THE TECHNOPACER-FORTUNE TOWNE

PUBLISHED BY THE STUDENTS OF
CARLOS HILADO MEMORIAL STATE UNIVERSITY
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ABOUT THE COVER

I wanted her sitting on something too big to be a fruit anymore, an apple swollen into a small mountain, the way memory swells the things we can't let go of. Beside her, an echo of her younger face watches from the clouds, soft and quiet, close but unreachable. The stars between them are unsettled on purpose, drifting like thoughts that haven't found where to land.

She carries the weight of who she used to be without letting it crush her. The open sky and endless grass leave room for both versions of her to exist at once, near enough to see each other, far enough apart to still be searching.

—Layout Artist, Nicole G. Magallona

FORWORD

We were all someone's child before we became anything else: a name on a class list, a height marked quietly on a doorframe, a future no one had asked us about yet. Childhood does not announce itself as something we will one day mourn. It simply happens, in scraped knees and borrowed bicycles, in afternoons that felt endless because we did not yet know what it meant for time to run out.

The apple becomes a mountain because that is what childhood does to memory: it takes the smallest, most ordinary objects, a fruit, a song, a particular slant of light through a window, and turns them into landmarks too large to ignore. We did not choose what we would remember. Memory chose for us, and we have spent the years since trying to understand why.

In these pages are letters to who we used to be, written by people who have carried their younger selves quietly for a long time, sometimes with tenderness, sometimes with the discomfort of recognizing how much has changed and how much, somehow, has not. There is no single way to look back. Some do it with grief. Some with gratitude. Most with both, tangled together the way they tend to be.

—Editor-in-Chief, Khryzyl Bray Dequilla

TABLE OF CONTENTS

01. GROWING UP DOESN'T MEAN GROWING APART

02. ENOLA

03. A Head Full of Fears has No Space for Dreams

04. THE LINGERING BLUSH OF A RIPE BERRY

05. TO MY YOUNGER SELF

06. You Were Never Meant to Blend In

07. THE GHOST OF WHO I WAS

08. tAGO'T HANAP

09. WHEN I WAS AN ANGEL WITH MY EYES CLOSED

WHEN I WAS AN ANGEL WITH MY EYES CLOSED

WRITTEN & ILLUSTRATED BY ***KARL G. ALMANZOR***

I used to think my ribs could hollow out into wings. Not metaphorically—I mean I could feel them wanting to. At night I'd lie flat and imagine the weight lifting, my small body finally understanding its purpose. The sky wasn't something separate then. It was just another room I hadn't entered yet.

I don't know exactly when I stopped trying. Maybe it was the first time someone laughed. Maybe it was just Tuesday, and I was tired. But somewhere between believing and growing, I learned to keep my feet planted. I learned that love meant staying still for people. That maturity meant burying the boy who thought he could touch clouds.

Now my shoulders carry the weight of feathers I'll never shed. They rest there like ghosts—evidence of something I almost became. I walk through rooms that used to be sky, and somewhere deep, that hollow space in my ribs still remembers how to ache for flight.

The wings never came.

But the longing never left either.

It just learned a different name: the weight of knowing what I could have been.

For some, answering these questions is like placing the final piece of a puzzle. For me, it felt like staring at a picture I could not complete.

Growing up, expectations had quietly rested on my shoulders. No one directly pressured me, yet the words "Kaya mo 'yan. Ikaw pa!" eventually stopped feeling like encouragement and became a burden. Hidden beneath every compliment was an unspoken demand. I kept striving, trying to fit into the world built around me, until one day, I became a stranger to myself.

It was never the pressure to succeed that hurt the most—it was realizing that somewhere along the way, I had turned into someone I no longer recognized. Then, the little girl's words echoed through my mind.

"Ate, dito muna ako magtatago habang hinahanap nila ako."

Before I knew it, I was standing in front of a mirror. I did not see my reflection. Instead, I saw the little girl. The realization hit me all at once —I was that little girl. For years, I had kept myself hidden, burying the dreams I once held close. While I was busy becoming the person everyone expected me to be, I lost sight of the person I wanted to become.
I stepped outside to look for her, only to find her running freely toward me—exhausted, sweat dripping down her face, yet her laughter was real. No fear in her eyes, no weight on her shoulders.

She paused and said, "Ate, ang tagal nila akong hinanap."

I pulled her into a hug and whispered, "Kung kailangan mong magtago sa lahat para maisalba ang sarili mo, gawin mo."

If I could leave my younger self a message, it would be this: life can be harsh, so run and hide as much as you need to. Reality will eventually catch up—but even then, you will keep moving forward. No matter how bumpy the road or how long it takes, you will find your way back to yourself.

Perhaps growing up is not about becoming someone new—it is about finding your way back to the person you buried beneath expectations.

At minsan, kailangan mo munang mawala sa paningin ng iba para muli mong matagpuan ang sarili mong matagal nang nawawala.

TAGO'T HANAP

WRITTEN BY ***SHYNE JAIN***
ILLUSTRATION BY ***MARGARETTE MARIE LUMAYNO***

"Pagbilang kong tatlo, nakatago na kayo. Isa, dalawa, tatlo..."

I was on my way home from school when I saw a group of kids playing outside. A little girl hiding behind a tree approached me and whispered, "Ate, dito muna ako magtatago habang hinahanap nila ako." I chuckled as I looked at her face—madungis pero malaya.

College has changed my life in ways I never imagined. Ever since I entered this chapter, I found myself asking the same questions almost every night: Am I really taking the right path? Is this what I truly want? The doubts lingered in the quiet spaces between deadlines and sleepless nights.

GROWING UP DOESN'T MEAN GROWING APART

WRITTEN BY ***JHON PATRICH ARROZ***

I wish I could sit beside you for a moment the way you are now, small hands full of big dreams, eyes lit up with a kind of hope that feels endless. You think growing up will mean becoming fearless, becoming whole. You don't realize yet how much courage it will take just to keep going.

You're going to face things you don't understand, there will be days when the world feels heavier than you ever thought it could be. You'll doubt yourself. You'll feel lost in ways that don't have easy answers. And sometimes, you'll wonder if you've drifted too far from the person you once were, but please hear me when I say this you never really lose yourself, because this version of you never stops existing.

You'll still be there in quiet moments, in the things that make my chest ache with nostalgia. In the dreams I almost forgot. In the soft voice that whispers, "Is this really what we wanted?" You don't fade away you wait. Patiently. Hopefully.And that's what breaks my heart the most.That somewhere along the way, I made you wait.

I got so busy trying to survive, trying to be who the world needed me to be, that I stopped listening to you. I buried your dreams under responsibility. I called them unrealistic. I told myself I'd come back to them "someday."But you never stopped believing in me.Even now, I can feel you still hoping, still trusting that I'll remember what mattered.

That I'll come back for you, that I'll finally become the person you always believed I could be.I'm so sorry it took me this long to understand.Growing up didn't mean leaving you behind. It meant carrying you with me protecting your dreams, not abandoning them. It meant becoming strong enough to face the world without losing the softness you gave me.So I promise you this I won't forget you anymore, I'll listen when you dream.

I'll try, even when it's hard. I'll chase the things that once made your heart feel alive. Not perfectly, not all at once, but honestly you're still in me. Still hoping. Still waiting.And I'm finally ready to come back for you

ARTWORK BY ***MARY JUNE DEBIDE***

THE GHOST OF WHO I WAS

WRITTEN BY ***GENEVIEVE BORNALES***

I see you clearly now—that tireless figure fueled by the quiet fear of being overlooked. You moved as if your worth was a currency earned through exhaustion, carrying a weight that no child was ever meant to shoulder. You turned every expectation into armor, unaware that it was slowly becoming a cage.

I know why you always pushed yourself so hard. You thought being the best was the only way to be seen, the only way to make your parents proud, and the only way to prove that you were worthy of love. You carried those heavy demands silently, turning pressure into motivation even when the well inside you had run dry. Every high grade and every compliment became a lifeline you clung to, terrified that slowing down would mean letting everyone fall.

But look at the person you were beyond the rankings and the awards. Your value was never measured by how much you could endure. There will be moments when life will not go according to the perfect plan you've sketched out. You will face failures that feel like endings, and setbacks that make you question your very foundation. At first, those moments will feel like punishments, but they are merely redirections. Every trial is quietly shaping a person wiser, kinder, and stronger than success alone ever could. Eventually, you will realize that not getting everything you wanted was actually life guiding you toward what you truly needed.

As the years pass, you will stop living for the applause and start discovering who you are in the silence. You will learn that rest is not a sign of laziness, mistakes are not evidence of weakness, and being lost is often the first step toward being found.

The pressure that once felt like a constant shadow will lose its power. You will find your own path, at your own pace, and it will be worth every heartbreak and every detour. So, I watch you now and wish you would be gentler with yourself. You do not have to earn your right to exist through constant success. Your future is not being ruined by these setbacks; it is being built by them.

PHOTO BY ***JOEMARIE PEREIRA***

ENOLA

WRITTEN BY ***TRISHA ALVARAN***

I saw a girl that plays so well,
In the crowd, she knows the rules of the game.
Give her a problem, give her a challenge,
I bet she solves it with no lame.

A lot of people say she's kind,
That she's brave, smart, simple, practical,
Knows how to listen, when to obey,
God, she perfectly does it all.

Sometimes she is unsure,
But she can deal with it later.
Not a swimmer, but she dives,
And somehow she still survives.

Smiles at the puzzle of life,
She's good on her own, and
Her name is
Enola.

In the end, these words
Meant the opposite—
Nice, but I'm not kind,
'Cause the truth is,

I am stupid, complicated,
Ambitious and not brave,
Want to rebel and speak my thoughts
Out loud and act it all.

I have been skeptical,
Cannot deal with the things that fell,
Told to swim though I am drowning,
Got no choice, the tide is changing.

I may be good on my own,
But I need something to hold.
Please, remember that I am
Enola.

Caught myself, that plays a part,
Forced to follow the rules of the game.
Kid's just a puppet of people's desires,
Must do what they expect, or kid will be damned.

LAYOUT BY JENILYN CONDES

To the Girl Who Was Always Running

*WRITTEN BY **JENNIFER DELOS REYES***

The ink on the parchment is finally dry. The caps have been tossed, the photographs taken, and the structured syllabus of your youth has reached its final page. For the first time in your life, there is no next semester, no looming deadline to anchor your anxiety, and no clear rubric for success.

You are standing at the finish line, and yet your lungs are still burning. You are still bracing for the next sprint.

For years, you were the girl who was always running. You measured your worth in milestones, in grades, in the constant pursuit of the next academic crest. Momentum was your safety net. As long as you were moving, you didn't have to ask yourself where you were actually going. Now the track has vanished, leaving you in an open, undefined field. The silence of this new freedom is deafening, and the pressure to map out a flawless career feels heavier than any final examination.

This is the great post-graduate dilemma. It is the jarring transition from having a clear path to having to forge one from scratch.
If I could send a dispatch back through time to the version of you standing frozen in that open field, the message would be simple: you have permission to stop running.

The panic gripping you right now is not a symptom of failure, and it is not proof that you are falling behind. It is simply the shock of slowing down. You are applying the frantic pacing of academia to the slow, deliberate work of building a life. They are different disciplines. The professional world does not run on a neat four-year timeline, and the most extraordinary careers are rarely linear.
The pressure to have everything figured out right this second is an illusion. The people you admire most, the ones sitting in the editor's chair and leading the charge, spent years stumbling through their own open fields. They took wrong turns, accepted jobs they outgrew, and faced the same paralyzing uncertainty that keeps you awake at night.

Do not let the anxiety of the unknown rob you of the present. You have done the work. You have earned this degree. Now you must learn the hardest skill of all: the courage to stand still long enough to catch your breath.

The world is not asking you to conquer it today. It is only asking you to step into it, one unhurried pace at a time.

PHOTO BY ***HARRON VILLAESTER***

A Head Full of Fears has No Space for Dreams

WRITTEN BY ***ERICA DE ASIS***

My dearest Ekay, more than anything, I wish you could see these words now, because I know there have been countless moments when you needed to hear exactly this. Out of all the people I've known throughout my life, you're the one who tends to feel anxious about nearly everything.

At such a young age, your thoughts are so consumed by your what ifs. You always wonder what happens if you try something new and find out you're bad at it. You always ask yourself what if you meet someone for the first time and they don't like you. If you speak up in class, people will think you don't know what you're talking about, and this always runs through your head. You worry constantly that if you share how you really feel, they will just laugh at you. You've been carrying all these concerns for so long, and to be honest, they're stopping you from pursuing what you truly want.

You keep telling yourself that if you just stay away from anything that makes you uneasy, you'll be okay. But the thing is, you're not really okay. You're missing out on life, and building walls around your heart and all the dreams you've got in there.

You turn down chances to make friends because you're terrified they won't like the real you. You won't even wear the clothes you like because you're stressing about what people might say. I want you to realize that most of the things you're so afraid of will probably never happen. And even if some of them do, you'll get through them. I can assure you of that. You're way stronger than you think you are.

Please don't let your fear control every single thought you have. Your mind has so much capacity for the things that bring you happiness, excitement, and make you feel alive.

You are so much bigger than all those fears put together, Ekay. Your dreams are waiting patiently for you. Make room for them. You have every right to live the life you can almost touch whenever you pause to breathe deeply and set your worries aside.

PHOTO BY **LERCON BORROMEO**

You Were Never Meant to Blend In

WRITTEN BY ***MA> DANIELLA BONACHE***

Growing up,
They taught me to follow
What society wanted me to be.

To walk the path already made,
to fit inside expectations
that never truly felt like mine.

But what if I don't want to?

How heavy it is
for a child so young
to carry a future
already planned by other hands.

A life decided
before they are even asked
what they truly want,
who they truly are.

Oh, little me,
How I wish I could turn back time
to the days when I believed
I could become anyone
without fear,
without judgment,
without a world so eager
to tear apart those
who choose differently.

Because society often points fingers
at what it does not understand.
It questions the unfamiliar,
criticizes the unique,
and fears those brave enough
to stand apart from the crowd.
And that is one of the very reasons.
Why do most of us choose to end it all
To hide, to lie low
until the fire slowly disappears.

However, being different
It is not something to hide
It is what makes you special.
It is what makes you you.

You are allowed to live
the life you want.
Whether it is your passion,

your dreams,

your sexuality,

your art,

or the path you choose to take
It is yours.

Let society judge if it wants to.
Their voices are only passing noise,
small distractions
in the story of your life.
Because at the end of it all,
the person who must live your life

It's you.

And that is what matters most.
So be different.
Be special.
Be free.
And above all

Be you.

PHOTO BY **ANNIE MARIE BALOYO**

A WHISPER TO A YOUNG SCRIBE

WRITTEN BY JAZIZ JUNSAN

To the one in the plaid shirt,
the tiny scribe under the golden shade,
whose world is held within a fuzzy purple pen
and the soft lines of a lavender page.
I see the map above you, all new worlds to find,
next to words your small hands haven't quite learned to define.

The walls are plastered with questions and rules,
But I need to tell you the real wisdom that's true.
You worry the pencil case isn't perfectly straight,
that the sharpeners won't catch all the graphite.
You worry your lines are wobbly and slow,
that you don't know the answers you're expected to know.

Look up at that wall, past the seed-pod strings,
past the Oak that is dreaming of bigger things.
See the ink I left you? It's not a command.
It's a hand-holding whisper to help you understand.
The map you are tracing? It's okay if it bends.
The paths that you write? They don't have to be perfect ends.

Your fuzzy purple pen will make blobs on the page,
But the blob is a signal, it's not a dead stage.
It's the proof you are trying, the proof you are growing.
Confusion isn't a problem, it's the way you are knowing.
Mistakes are just teachers, all dressed up as falls,
They help you climb over the tallest of walls.
So scribble that thought that feels lost in your mind.
Draw the lines that are crooked, let the answers be kind.

Because, darling scribe, I need you to know
The map isn't made until after you go.
You don't have to have it figured out,
you don't have to see the end of the route.
It's okay to be lost. I am here on this shore,
Just keep writing your story, I couldn't want more.

THE LINGERING BLUSH OF A RIPE BERRY

WRITTEN BY ***SARAH GWYNETH SANCHO***

Fruits that are picked too early may survive the journey, but they never quite taste the same — yet some of the most beautiful things in this world leave their color behind long after they are gone.

In a yard with overflowing berries, there was you, a tiny little one who was carried into an unfamiliar space, trying to shrank to fit in a soil that was never really built to hold your roots.

When great skies appear, there came a beautiful day and a hope to begin again.

But when storms come, you were such in hurry to ripen waiting to be picked up and brought in a warm basket.

And so you ripened too soon — not because the season asked you to, but because you feared what would happen if you don't allow yourself to grow.

It made you start to reach the sun and be thirsty to be filled with water.
Unlike any other berries, yours was a difficult blooming phase.
That on these days, it molded you into who you are today.

As that little tiny berry chose to grow quietly, the blush begins to linger upon. Without apologizing for the space it needed.

That today it made her looked back on the days. But for this moment and time, storms no longer frightened the not so little one.

TO MY YOUNGER SELF

WRITTEN BY ***MARISSA P. PANOGALING***

It's been a while since we last spoke in earnest,
But please know, you are not forgotten.
Perhaps I got too busy in this vast universe,
Yet today, I am back with this truth—
You are remembered, loved, and deeply cared for.
I want to commend you, my dear,
for being brave yet compassionate,
for standing strong in the face of the world's realities.
Again and again, you have shown the world.
that you are worthy of all the respect and love you deserve.
You make me proud of who you've become—
of every achievement you've earned,
of every life you've touched and quietly influenced,
of the unseen help you offer
that inspires others to rise and follow your lead.
I love you more each day, my dear,
for your honesty, your persistence, your assertiveness.
For holding your ground—for yourself and for others.
For the positive energy you carry,
that helps others grow and dare to become like you.
Today, I want you to know this vividly:
You are deeply loved, honored, and adored.
You are you—please never change.
For some people, look up to you,
who find strength in your light.
So, let this be your reminder, now and always:
I choose, protect and value you.
I love you more every day than I did before.

ARTWORK BY ***MARIAH JANELLE MISOLA***

The unfamiliar soil begins to feel comfortable and it teaches the berry how to stay rooted.

The cold winds no longer bothers its stem to bend, as it is now built stronger.

For the very meant moment, you stopped waiting for someone to picked you up instead you allow your own to bear a lasting blush.
Now, you make room for you.

You let your roots wander deeper,
until the unfamiliar soil
slowly learned your name.

The blush that begins to wander was no longer shame for occupying a space it once think it was not belong, it became a proof that you endured every season you thought it would destroy you.

And though a part of you still longed
for warm baskets and gentle hands,
you finally understood that not every berry is meant to be picked quickly.

Some are meant to remain beneath the open sky, growing in their own time, until sweetness comes naturally.

And just like that, now you were found. Wrapped in a warm basket, embraced fully by the instruments that built you. Finally chosen to be one of the ripest berry.

A ripe berry that does not apologize for its color. It becomes fuller, sweeter, and softer.

This lingering blush I carry is a testimony of a ripe berry. It feels like a faint stain left on fingertips after holding something fragile for too long — not something to erase, but something that proves I once existed gently in that space, and grew in quiet ways because of it.

ARTWORK BY ***KEISHA MARIE BARNUEVO***